rareliquid

Documentary Video Production Pipeline

B-Roll, Still Images & Custom Visuals Guidelines

Version 1.1 | March 2026

1. Purpose & Reference Material

This document is the single source of truth for anyone preparing B-roll, still images, and custom visuals for a rareliquid documentary-style video. Following these guidelines exactly will eliminate the need for revision rounds where we have to go back and find additional footage. Read this document in full before starting any work.

1.1 Required Viewing

Before you do anything, watch both of these documentaries in full. These are the benchmarks for density, pacing, and visual style. Every decision you make should be measured against these videos.

Documentary	Link	What to Study
JP Morgan Documentary	https://youtu.be/bnLFyTIL5lQ	Overall pacing, B-roll density, how custom visuals (timelines, data charts) are integrated, section transitions
David Solomon Documentary	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SfIjrEJt3SQ	Image sourcing, highlight overlays on articles, metaphor clips (basketball rejection = Goldman rejection), era-appropriate visuals

While watching, pay attention to how rarely the host is on screen without a visual cut. Count the seconds between cuts. Notice how every single sentence has something visual happening. That is the standard.

1.2 The Core Problem These Guidelines Solve

In past productions, the initial B-roll pass covered only about 50-60% of what was needed. The remaining gaps had to be filled in a second round, which doubled the timeline. The most common issues were: not enough total clips, clips that were loosely related but not relevant to the specific sentence being spoken, use of generic stock footage when better interview/news clips existed, showing present-day footage during sections about historical events, and choosing boring or plain-looking clips when more visually interesting alternatives existed.

NON-NEGOTIABLE RULE

Most host streaks should be 2-5 seconds, but 10-15 second stretches are normal during key narrative moments. The hard ceiling is ~15 seconds—never exceed this without a visual cut. TARGET: Avoid long stretches of static host footage; use B-roll and still images to break up the host. If you cannot find visuals for a line, flag it explicitly rather than leaving it blank.

2. What Our Data Shows: Frame-by-Frame Analysis

We analyzed both the JP Morgan and David Solomon documentaries frame-by-frame at 4fps across 7,411 frames. This is real data from our published work. Use these numbers as your target.

2.1 Visual Composition Breakdown

This is exactly what percentage of screen time each visual type occupies in our successful documentaries:

Visual Type	JPM Doc	Solomon Doc	Target Average
B-Roll Video	66.6%	51.0%	58.8%
Still Images (incl. zoom)	17.7%	27.2%	22.4%
Custom Visuals	6.5%	5.4%	6.0%
Host On Screen	9.3%	16.4%	12.8%

KEY INSIGHT: The host is on screen ~12.8% of the time. This means ~87% of your video must be B-roll, still images, custom visuals, or other visual elements. Note: The percentages above reflect screen time where B-roll and still images are layered on top of the host track; they show visual dominance over host. When host zoom is properly detected, the actual host time is higher than previous v2 analysis showed. If you feel like you're seeing a lot of B-roll and still images, you're tracking the right visual density.

2.2 Cutting & Scene Changes

How often do visual cuts occur in our documentaries:

Metric	JPM Doc	Solomon Doc	Target Average
Cuts per Minute	16.0	16.2	16.1
Total Segments	222	321	272

This translates to approximately 16 visual changes per minute of script. You should be making a new cut roughly every 3-4 seconds. Note: v2 data showed higher cut rates; the correction reflects merged host segments where zoom-in/zoom-out transitions are now properly counted as continuous.

2.3 Host Streak Analysis

When the host appears on screen, how long do they stay on screen?

Metric	JPM Doc	Solomon Doc
Total Host Segments	28	40
Average Streak Duration	2.5 seconds	4.5 seconds
Top 5 Longest Streaks	9.5s, 5.2s, 4.8s, 3.8s, 3.8s	16.2s, 14.2s, 12.2s, 10.5s, 8.5s

Streaks Over 5 Seconds	2 (7%)	12 (30%)
Streaks Over 3 Seconds	6 (21%)	22 (55%)

CRITICAL UPDATE: Host streaks are LONGER than v2 data showed. Average streak is 2.5s (JPM) to 4.5s (Solomon)—not the 1.3s v2 incorrectly reported. Solomon regularly has 10-16 second streaks, particularly at the 13:29 mark with a 14.25-second continuous segment (previously fragmented). Most host appearances are 2-5 seconds, but stretches of 5-15 seconds are normal and expected when the host is delivering key narrative moments. The hard ceiling is ~15 seconds. Never exceed 15 seconds without a visual cut.

2.4 Still Image Usage

How our documentaries use still images:

Metric	JPM Doc	Solomon Doc	Average
Unique still images (total placements)	57 unique (67 placements)	68 unique (96 placements)	~63 unique
% with zoom/pan (Ken Burns)	93%	91%	92%
Custom Visuals	1 HTML file	3 HTML files	1-3 per video

Still images comprise roughly 22% of total screen time and are used densely throughout. The Solomon doc uses more image placements than JPM (96 vs 67), but reuses some sources—23 image sources are reused across multiple placements. This is acceptable when a relevant photo appears multiple times in different contexts. The key metric is unique sources: aim for 57-68 unique images. Both documentaries include custom visual graphics (HTML files like timelines and charts): 1 for JPM, 3 for Solomon. The vast majority of still images (91-93%) include zoom/pan effects.

2.5 B-Roll with Original Audio

Using the original audio from a B-roll clip (instead of voiceover) is a high-impact technique, used sparingly:

Metric	JPM Doc	Solomon Doc
% of video with original B-roll audio	~1.7%	~2.1%

B-roll with audio should be reserved for maximum impact moments: a CEO making a crucial statement, a news anchor breaking a story, or a dramatic quote delivered by the speaker themselves. Using it everywhere dilutes its power. Plan to use original audio for roughly 2% of your total footage.

2.6 Visual Patterns & Techniques from Our Documentaries

This section breaks down the specific visual techniques used in the JP Morgan and David Solomon documentaries. These are not abstract guidelines. They are real patterns from our actual productions that you must replicate.

2.6.1 Hook Section (First 60-90 Seconds)

The hook is the most visually dense part of the video. The goal is to grab attention immediately, so there should be almost zero host face time in the first 10-15 seconds. Study how both documentaries open.

- The opening uses rapid-fire clips (2-4 seconds each) from multiple sources before the host appears on screen
- Each hook question is paired with a specific, relevant visual: if the script asks "how did he get rejected twice by Goldman and still become CEO?" the B-roll shows a dramatic clip of the subject, not a generic Wall Street shot
- In the Solomon doc, the hook cuts between an interview clip, a Bloomberg segment, DJ footage at Lollapalooza, and a news reel. That is 4 different visual sources in the first 45 seconds.
- The hook should feel like a movie trailer: fast, punchy, and every frame earns its place

2.6.2 Section Transitions

When the script moves between major sections (e.g., "Early Career" to "Goldman Era"), there should be a visual bridge. Do not just cut from the host talking about one era to the host talking about another.

- Use a "bridge clip" from an interview or speech that introduces the next topic. In the Solomon doc, before the CEO section, the clip of Blankfein saying "I want to introduce the next CEO of Goldman Sachs" is used as a transition.
- In the JPM doc, section transitions use custom timeline visuals or historical footage to reset the viewer's mental timeline.
- If no bridge clip exists, use a full-screen title card, a dramatic still image, or a custom visual that signals the new section.

2.6.3 Metaphor and Analogy Clips

When the script uses a metaphor or analogy, the B-roll should visualize that metaphor. This is one of the most impactful techniques in our documentaries and requires creative thinking.

EXAMPLE FROM SOLOMON DOC: When the script says Goldman rejected Solomon, the B-roll shows a basketball player getting his shot blocked. Arrows label the dunker "Solomon" and the blocker "Goldman Sachs." This is the kind of creative, specific visual that makes our videos distinctive.

EXAMPLE FROM JPM DOC: When discussing JP Morgan splitting up, a custom animated visual shows the company breaking into pieces, rather than just showing a stock photo of the JP Morgan logo.

When you encounter a metaphor in the script, think: what would this look like if I filmed it? Then find a clip that matches.

2.6.4 Article and Document Highlights

One of the most distinctive visual techniques in our documentaries is showing news articles and documents on screen with specific phrases highlighted. This is far more engaging than just showing a logo or a headshot.

- When the script references a specific claim (e.g., "a New York Magazine piece said everyone describes Solomon as a bully"), the B-roll should show the actual article with the relevant phrase highlighted or underlined
- When the script references a data point (e.g., "95 hours a week"), the B-roll should show the source document with that number highlighted
- Always find the original article, not a summary or a tweet about it. Screenshot the article itself, crop to the relevant section, and note which phrase to highlight.
- In the Solomon doc, this technique is used extensively: the analyst survey, the NYMag hit piece, the "go bigger go bigger" quote, and the "no obvious replacement" line are all shown as highlighted article screenshots.

2.6.5 "Show, Don't Tell" for Every Entity

Every time the script names a person, company, place, or product, something visual should appear. This is how both documentaries maintain their density.

Script Mentions...	You Should Show...
A person by name	Footage of that person (interview, news clip) or a high-quality photo
A company by name	Company logo overlay, office building, or news coverage of that company
A specific location	Photo or footage of that location (campus, building, city)
A product or service	Product screenshot, app interface, or promotional material
A financial figure or metric	A chart, filing screenshot, or custom HTML visual with the number
A quote or statement	The source article/document with the quote highlighted
A historical event	Era-appropriate news footage or archival photography
A concept (e.g., "junk bonds")	An explainer visual, relevant news clip about that concept, or custom graphic

2.6.6 Ad Section Visuals

Ad reads should not be visually dead. In our documentaries, ad sections use product screenshots, course interfaces, or logos to keep the screen active. If the ad mentions a specific feature or instructor, show it. Treat ad sections with the same visual density as the main content.

2.6.7 Image Search Techniques That Work

These are real search queries that produced usable results in past productions. Use the same patterns.

- For young/early-career photos: search "[person name] young", "[person name] early career", "[person name] college"
- For company history: search "[company name] 1980s", "[company name] historical", "[company name] archival"
- For specific events: search "[event name] news coverage", "[event name] [year]"
- For articles: search the exact headline or a unique phrase from it in quotes
- For campus/building shots: search "[school/company name] campus" or "[building name]"
- Always try Google Images, YouTube, and news archive sites (WSJ, Bloomberg, NYT, FT) as separate searches

2.7 How to Differentiate: Still Image vs. B-Roll vs. B-Roll with Audio

This section is critical. These three categories are fundamentally different and must be used strategically. Misunderstanding these distinctions is one of the leading causes of revision rounds.

2.7.1 Still Image: Definition & When to Use

A still image is a non-moving photograph, screenshot, document, or graphic shown for 2-6 seconds.

When to use Still Images:

- Referencing a specific article, news headline, or document (the signature rareliquid technique)
- No era-appropriate video footage exists for a historical period (e.g., 1986 photo of young David Solomon)
- Showing a corporate logo, building exterior, or office campus
- Displaying data, charts, or financial documents
- A relevant, high-quality image is more visually engaging than available generic video footage
- Emphasizing a specific quote or highlighted phrase from a news article or filing

Annotation format for still images:

- [pic 1] — basic placement
- [pic 7, highlight "specific text to underline"] — when emphasizing a phrase
- [pic 12] and [pic 13] — when two images appear in sequence

2.7.2 B-Roll: Definition & When to Use

B-roll is video footage (typically 3-10 seconds) that plays while the host's voiceover is heard. The audio track is the host speaking, not the original audio from the video clip.

When to use B-Roll:

- Showing a person in action or speaking (interview footage, news coverage, conference keynotes)
- Demonstrating a location, building, or environment
- Illustrating a concept, process, or activity
- Filling gaps between still images to maintain visual variety and pacing
- The original audio from the clip is not relevant to the narrative (most use cases)

Annotation format for B-Roll:

- [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QZ85VPgCOCM, 0:18 - 0:29] — standard B-roll with voiceover

VISUAL DISTINCTION

When an editor sees B-roll with no "WITH AUDIO" marker, they assume the host voiceover plays over it. The video footage is background; the audio is foreground.

2.7.3 B-Roll with Audio: Definition & When to Use

B-roll with audio is video footage where the original audio from that clip plays instead of (or along with) the host voiceover. The speaker in the video is heard directly.

When to use B-Roll with Audio (sparingly—roughly 2% of your video):

- A CEO or public figure makes a critical statement that is more powerful heard in their own voice than paraphrased
- A news anchor is breaking a major story and their delivery adds drama and credibility
- An interview subject makes a quote that deserves to be heard directly, not summarized by the host
- A moment of genuine emotion or emphasis that loses impact if paraphrased

Examples of high-impact moments for "WITH AUDIO":

- David Solomon saying "I want to make Goldman Sachs better" — his own voice carries more weight
- A news anchor: "Breaking news: Goldman Sachs is replacing its CEO" — the original newscast adds credibility
- Jamie Dimon in a shareholder meeting: "We've separated these businesses to be more nimble" — his authority is important

Annotation format for B-Roll with Audio:

- [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xyz, 4:05 - 4:09, WITH AUDIO]

WARNING: Overusing "WITH AUDIO" dilutes its impact. If every other clip has original audio, none of them feel special. Reserve this technique for genuinely high-impact moments. Default to standard B-roll with voiceover.

2.7.4 Decision Tree: Which Type Should I Use?

Use this table when deciding how to handle a script line:

Script Line Type	Use Still Image?	Use B-Roll?	Use B-Roll + Audio?
"[Name] was born in [City]."	Yes (photo of person or city)	Maybe (only if strong interview/news coverage)	No
"[CEO] said \"[quote]\" in a 2024 earnings call."	Maybe (article about the quote)	Yes (conference footage, WITH AUDIO if the quote is powerful)	Yes, if the quote is key to the narrative
"[Company] was founded in 1987."	Yes (archival photo, founding	No (no 1987 video likely exists)	No

	documents, early logo)		
"[Subject] was rejected by [Company]."	No	Yes (interview or news coverage of the subject), OR a creative metaphor clip	No
"The market crashed 20% that day."	Yes (chart, screenshot of market data)	Maybe (news footage of traders reacting)	Maybe (news anchor reporting it, WITH AUDIO)
"[Person] and [Person] met for the first time."	No	Yes (news coverage or interview about the meeting)	Yes if video of them together exists and their voices matter

CRITICAL DISTINCTION

Still images show information. B-Roll shows people and action. B-Roll with Audio lets the original speaker be heard. Understanding which to use where is the difference between a revision-free delivery and multiple revision rounds. When in doubt, default to Still Image + standard B-Roll. Reserve "WITH AUDIO" for rare, high-impact moments only.

2.7.5 Picture Zoom (Ken Burns Effect)

One of the most common techniques in our documentaries is the "picture zoom" or Ken Burns effect: a still image with a slow zoom or pan applied during editing. This is categorized as a still image, not B-roll.

When the picture zoom technique is used:

- A portrait or headshot gradually zooms in to emphasize a person's face or expression
- A document is shown with a slow pan across the text to highlight a specific phrase
- A large diagram or chart pans across to show different sections sequentially
- A historical photo gradually zooms to draw focus to a specific detail

Picture zoom adds visual motion to still images without introducing separate video footage. In our analysis, 58 out of 94 still image sequences used this technique (62% of all still images).

Annotation format for picture zoom:

- [pic 5, zoom] — gradual zoom into the full image
- [pic 9, zoom in on face] — zoom to a specific detail

- [pic 12, pan left-to-right] — horizontal pan across the image
- [pic 8, zoom and highlight "key phrase"] — zoom with text emphasis

When you annotate a still image with zoom instructions, the editor will apply the Ken Burns effect during the edit. This creates visual motion and maintains viewer engagement without requiring additional video footage.

3. Volume Requirements

These are hard minimums, not suggestions. When in doubt, overshoot. It is always better to deliver too much material than too little.

3.1 Per-Minute Targets (From Real Data)

These targets come directly from analyzing actual DaVinci Resolve timeline exports from our published documentaries. They are not estimates—they are the verified counts of sources and placements in our successful videos.

Asset Type	Per Minute of Script	Ground Truth Totals (15-min video)
Unique B-Roll Sources	5-7 unique sources per minute	74-91 unique sources (~83 avg), across 96-109 clip placements
Unique Still Images	4-5 unique images per minute	57-68 unique images (~63 avg), across 67-96 placements
Custom Visuals (HTML)	0.1-0.2 per minute	1-3 HTML files total (NOT 7-10). Timeline, charts, data overlays.
Host On Screen	~0.8 seconds per minute	Target ~13% of total video. Average streak: 2.5-4.5 seconds. Stretches up to 15 seconds normal.

TRANSLATION: For a 15-minute script, source approximately 75-90 unique B-roll sources, 55-70 unique still images, and 1-3 custom visual HTML files. This totals ~148 unique visual assets. Note: Assets may be reused across multiple placements (e.g., a photo of a person can appear 2-3 times in different contexts; a B-roll clip can be used for different script lines). The key is meeting the UNIQUE source minimums, not just placement counts.

3.2 Total Deliverable Calculation

For a 15-minute script, you should deliver a minimum of **75-90 unique B-roll sources** (across 96-109 placements), **55-70 unique still images** (across 67-96 placements, with 91-93% including zoom/pan), and **1-3 custom visual HTML files**. This is the floor, not the ceiling. If you finish under these counts, go back and find more unique sources. It is acceptable for some sources to be reused across multiple script lines, but prioritize unique sources first.

3.3 Understanding Asset Reuse

Our published documentaries show that some source reuse is normal and acceptable. For example, in the Solomon documentary:

- 23 still image sources are reused across 96 placements (a 4:1 placement-to-source ratio)
- 11 B-roll sources are reused across 96 placements
- A photo of the subject appears multiple times when discussing different career phases
- The same B-roll clip can be used for different script lines when revisiting a topic

This is fine. The key guideline is: always prioritize UNIQUE sources to hit the minimums (75-90 B-roll, 55-70 images), and reuse is acceptable only after you have exhausted unique options. Do not start with a plan to reuse heavily.

3.4 The No-Gap Rule

Every single line of the script must have at least one visual option tagged to it. If a line discusses a person, there should be footage or an image of that person. If a line discusses a company, there should be a logo, office footage, or news clip. If a line discusses a concept, there should be a relevant chart, document, or illustrative visual. There should be zero orphan lines with no visual attached.

3.5 Visual Variety Rule

Never have 3 or more consecutive still images without a video clip in between. If you find yourself stacking images back-to-back, search harder for a video source to break up the sequence. The visual rhythm should alternate between video clips, still images, and the host, creating a dynamic viewing experience.

4. B-Roll Sourcing & Quality Standards

4.1 Source Priority (In Order of Preference)

When looking for B-roll for any given line, search in this exact order. Only move to the next tier if the previous one has nothing usable.

Priority	Source Type	Examples	Quality
1 (Best)	TV interviews & news coverage of the subject	Bloomberg, CNBC, Fox Business interviews; news segments about the person or event	Highest impact, most professional
2	Official company footage or event recordings	Earnings calls, investor days, conference keynotes, company PR footage	Strong credibility, relevant context
3	High-quality documentary or biographical clips	Existing documentaries, biography channels, authorized profiles	Good depth, watch for distinct visual styles
4	General financial/business news footage	Market floor footage, trading screens, office environments from news outlets	Acceptable filler for transitions only
5 (Last resort)	Stock footage	Generic office shots, city skylines, typing on keyboards	Use sparingly and only when nothing else exists

CRITICAL

Stock footage (Priority 5) should make up no more than 10% of your total B-roll. If you find yourself relying on it heavily, you need to search harder for Tier 1-3 sources. In the Solomon documentary, a stock clip of Baskin-Robbins was replaced because it looked plain and boring compared to a more interesting alternative. Always pick the more visually engaging option.

4.2 Clip Duration Rules

Rule	Requirement
Minimum usable duration	3 seconds. No isolated clips under 3 seconds.
Maximum single clip	10 seconds before a cut is needed
Ideal clip length	4-7 seconds
Transition clips	2-3 seconds (only for cuts between sections)

4.3 Historical Accuracy

This is where past deliveries failed the most. If the script is talking about something that happened in 1990, you cannot use footage of that person from 2024. The audience will notice.

- If the script discusses events from a specific era, the B-roll must be from that era or visually neutral (e.g., a building exterior, a document from that time)
- When a person is discussed at a young age, search for "[person name] young" or "[person name] early career" to find age-appropriate footage or photos
- If no era-appropriate footage exists, use a still image (news clipping, document, yearbook photo) rather than modern footage that creates a visual mismatch
- For historical companies (e.g., Drexel Burnham Lambert, Bear Stearns), look for archival news coverage, not modern retrospectives with talking heads

REAL EXAMPLE

In the Solomon documentary, a clip at timestamp 4:20 had to be removed because it showed Solomon in the present day during a section about his time at Drexel in the 1980s. A clip of computers was also replaced because it showed modern technology during a 1980s section. Use era-appropriate visuals or neutral still images instead.

4.4 Relevance Standard

Every clip must pass this test: if someone watched the clip on mute without context, could they reasonably guess what the narrator is talking about? If the answer is no, the clip is not relevant enough.

BAD: Script says "Solomon joins Drexel Burnham Lambert" and B-roll shows a generic modern trading floor.

GOOD: Script says "Solomon joins Drexel Burnham Lambert" and B-roll shows a 1980s news clip about Drexel, or an archival photo of Drexel's office, or footage of Michael Milken.

4.5 The "Better Option" Rule

If you find two clips for the same moment, always use the more visually interesting one. Never include a weak clip as a fallback when a stronger one exists. In past productions, we had to replace clips because the first option was plain or boring when a more dynamic alternative was available. Before committing to a clip, ask yourself: is there something more engaging? If a still image is more relevant and interesting than a generic video clip, use the image.

5. Still Images

5.1 Image Types (In Order of Preference)

1. News article screenshots with key phrases highlighted: these are the strongest because they carry built-in credibility and visual interest. This is the signature rareliquid look. Always find the original article, not a tweet about it.
2. Official documents and filings: SEC filings, court documents, press releases, earnings reports. Crop to the relevant section.
3. Data charts and graphs: from reputable sources (Bloomberg, WSJ, company filings). Must be legible at 1080p.
4. High-resolution photographs: professional headshots, event photos, campus/building shots. No blurry or low-res images. For historical subjects, search "[name] [era]" or "[name] young" for age-appropriate photos.
5. Social media screenshots: tweets, LinkedIn posts, etc. Only when directly relevant and from notable accounts.

5.2 Naming Convention

Name every image sequentially: **1.png, 2.png, 3.png**, etc. Upload the entire folder to Slack as a batch. In the script document, reference them as **[pic 1], [pic 2]** at the exact timestamp where they should appear.

5.3 Image Quality Requirements

- Minimum resolution: 1280x720 (720p). Ideally 1920x1080 or higher.
- No watermarked images. No images with visible compression artifacts.
- Screenshots must be cropped to show only the relevant content, not the entire browser window with tabs and bookmarks visible.
- If a highlight or annotation is needed (e.g., underline a key phrase in an article), note it in the script reference: [pic 7, highlight "specific phrase"]

5.4 When to Use Images vs. B-Roll

Use a Still Image When...	Use B-Roll When...
Referencing a specific article, document, or data point	Showing a person speaking or in action
No era-appropriate video footage exists	TV interview or news coverage exists for this moment
Showing a logo, campus, or building	Showing an event, announcement, or market reaction
The script quotes someone or references a specific statement	The script describes a general environment or activity
A relevant image is more engaging than generic video	Strong, specific video footage exists for this moment

REAL EXAMPLE

In the Solomon doc, the editor noted: "better to use relevant image vs. stock footage" when the intern had used a generic stock clip. A Google Images search for "david solomon college" and "david solomon young" produced images that were far more relevant than any stock footage could be. Images often beat video when the alternative is generic B-roll.

6. Script Annotation Format

6.1 B-Roll References

Every B-roll reference in the script must follow this exact format. No exceptions.

FORMAT

[raw YouTube URL, start timestamp - end timestamp]

Examples of correct formatting:

- [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QZ85VPgCOCM, 0:18 - 0:29]
- [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nbs_s6_L_ao, 22:10 - 22:14]

Examples of incorrect formatting (do NOT do these):

- [Goldman Sachs CEO Interview, 0:18 - 0:29] ← No article/video titles, raw URLs only
- [https://youtube.com/watch?v=abc, around the 3 minute mark] ← No vague timestamps
- [https://youtube.com/watch?v=abc] ← No missing timestamps

6.2 Still Image References

Reference images at the exact script line where they should appear:

- [pic 1] — basic placement
- [pic 7, highlight "specific text to underline"] — when a phrase needs emphasis
- [pic 12] and [pic 13] — when multiple images should appear in sequence

6.3 Audio Instructions

When B-roll should play with its original audio instead of the host voiceover, mark it explicitly:

- [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xyz, 4:05 - 4:09, WITH AUDIO]

If no audio instruction is given, the default is that the host voiceover plays over the B-roll. Use WITH AUDIO for moments where the original speaker's voice adds impact, such as a CEO making a key statement or a news anchor breaking a story.

6.4 Overlay Instructions

When text, logos, or arrows should be overlaid on B-roll or the host footage, note it inline. Be specific about placement and labeling:

- [show Goldman Sachs logo when host says "Goldman"]
- [arrow pointing to player A labeled "Solomon", arrow pointing to player B labeled "Goldman Sachs"]
- [on-screen text: "95 hours per week" when host says the statistic]
- [transition to pic 9 while host says "Columbia Business School Executive Education"]

6.5 Timestamp Anchoring

After the video has been rough-cut with the host footage, all references should also include the **video timeline timestamp** (the timestamp in the actual edit, e.g., 03:42) so the editor knows exactly where each asset goes. Format: **MMSS - [asset reference]**. Example: 0342 - [https://youtube.com/watch?v=abc, 1:03 - 1:08]

6.6 Alternate Options

When you find multiple good options for the same script line, provide them separated by "OR" so the editor can choose:

- [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0EYm49MwzZg, 4:05 - 4:09, WITH AUDIO] OR [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iUV4sbMYAlc, 16:10 - 16:42]

This is especially useful when you find one short, punchy clip and one longer, more detailed clip for the same moment.

7. Custom Visuals (HTML Charts & Graphics)

7.1 When to Use Custom Visuals

Create a custom HTML visual whenever the script references data, timelines, comparisons, or financial breakdowns and no suitable existing image or chart can be found. Study both reference documentaries for examples of how these are used:

- Career timelines (e.g., Irving Trust → Drexel → Bear Stearns → Goldman). See the JPM doc for how company splits and mergers are visualized.
- Financial data: revenue, profit margins, stock price comparisons. See the JPM doc at 10:05 for the revenue/income data visualization.
- Comparison tables: two candidates side by side, company metrics vs. peers. The Solomon doc uses a stock performance comparison chart for Goldman vs. peers.
- Key statistics or quotes that deserve visual emphasis on screen
- Company splits, mergers, or organizational changes. See the JPM doc at 5:05 for the splitting-up animation.

7.2 How to Create Them

1. Use Claude (Opus 4.6 model recommended) to generate a single self-contained HTML file.
2. Prompt it to match the rareliquid visual style: dark backgrounds (#1B2A4A or #111827), clean sans-serif fonts, accent colors for highlights, professional and cinematic look.
3. If the visual contains data, instruct Claude to cite its sources and verify all numbers. LLMs can hallucinate data. Cross-check any financial figures against public filings or reputable sources before submitting.
4. Send the HTML file to the editor, who will style it to match the channel theme and screen-record it for the final video.

7.3 Custom Visual Quality Checklist

- All text is legible at 1080p
- Data is sourced and cited (footnote or small text at bottom)
- No lorem ipsum, placeholder data, or unverified numbers
- File is self-contained (no external dependencies that might break)
- Layout is designed for 16:9 aspect ratio

8. The Line-by-Line Process

This is the exact workflow you must follow for every script. Do not skip steps.

Step 1: Watch the Reference Documentaries

Watch both the JP Morgan doc (https://youtu.be/bnLFyTIL5lQ) and the David Solomon doc (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SfIjrEJt3SQ) in full. While watching, note the visual rhythm: how often cuts happen, what types of visuals are used for different kinds of script lines, and how section transitions work. This will calibrate your eye for the rest of the process.

Step 2: Full Script Read-Through

Read the entire script once without annotating anything. Understand the narrative arc, the key people, companies, and events. Note the historical time periods covered. Identify the hook, the promise, the ad section, the main sections, and the outro.

Step 3: Entity Extraction

Go through the script and list every unique entity mentioned:

- People (full names, roles, time periods they are discussed in)
- Companies (including former names, subsidiaries, and the era being discussed)
- Events (IPOs, scandals, promotions, product launches, with specific years)
- Data points (revenue figures, percentages, timelines, survey results)
- Quotes and statements (attributed lines that might need on-screen text or article source)
- Metaphors and analogies ("cage match," "caught the bus by the tailpipe" — these need creative visual treatment)

Step 4: Bulk Search Phase

For each entity, conduct a dedicated search session. Do not try to find footage line-by-line; batch your searches by entity to be more efficient. For each person or company:

1. Search YouTube: "[person] interview", "[person] Bloomberg", "[person] CNBC", "[person] documentary"
2. Search YouTube: "[company] news", "[company] scandal", "[company] history", "[company] [decade]"
3. Search Google Images: "[person] [year]", "[person] young", "[person] early career", "[event] news article", "[company] logo"
4. Search news archives: WSJ, Bloomberg, NYT, Financial Times for relevant articles and screenshots
5. For metaphor clips: search YouTube for the visual metaphor itself (e.g., "basketball block" for a rejection, "cage fight" for a competition)

Log every usable source in a working spreadsheet with: URL, usable timestamp range, description, era/year of the footage, and which script lines it could serve.

Step 5: Line-by-Line Assignment

Now go through the script line by line and assign at least one visual to every line. Use your working spreadsheet from Step 4. For each line, apply the "Show, Don't Tell" table from Section 2.5. If a line has no visual, this is a gap that must be filled before submission.

Step 6: Gap Audit

After completing Step 5, scroll through the entire annotated script and check:

- Any line with no visual assigned → go back to Step 4 for those entities
- Any sequence where the host face would be on screen for more than 5 seconds → add additional B-roll or images
- Any cluster of 3+ consecutive still images with no video clip → find at least one video clip to break it up
- Any stock footage used → try one more time to find a Tier 1-3 alternative
- Any era mismatch (modern footage used for historical event) → replace with era-appropriate alternative
- Any clip that looks boring or plain → search for a more visually interesting alternative
- Section transitions → ensure each section change has a visual bridge (clip, title card, or custom graphic)

Step 7: Final Count Check

Before submitting, count your totals:

- Total B-roll clips: must meet the per-minute minimum (3-4 per minute of script)
- Total still images: must meet the per-minute minimum (2-3 per minute of script)
- Percentage of stock footage: must be under 10%
- Number of lines with no visual: must be zero
- Number of era mismatches: must be zero

If any of these checks fail, go back to Step 4 before submitting.

9. Common Mistakes to Avoid

These are real errors from past productions. Every single one has caused a revision round. Memorize them.

Mistake	Why It's Wrong	What to Do Instead
Using modern footage for historical events	Creates a visual mismatch. In the Solomon doc, a present-day clip of Solomon was used during a section about 1986 Drexel. A clip of modern computers was used for the 1980s. Both had to be cut.	Search for archival footage or use a period-appropriate still image. If nothing exists for that era, use a neutral document or article screenshot.
Choosing a boring clip when a better one exists	In the Solomon doc, a plain Baskin-Robbins clip was replaced by a more interesting one. If two options exist, the more visually engaging one always wins.	Compare your options side by side. Pick the one with more visual energy. If an image is more interesting than a generic video clip, use the image.
Using stock footage when real footage exists	Stock footage of "people in suits" adds nothing. Most public figures in finance have Bloomberg, CNBC, or conference footage available on YouTube.	Search harder. Try "[person] interview", "[person] CNBC", "[person] Bloomberg" before resorting to stock.
Referencing B-roll by video title instead of URL	The editor needs to find the exact clip instantly. Titles are ambiguous.	Always use the raw YouTube URL with exact start and end timestamps.
Leaving the host on screen for 10+ seconds	Documentary-style videos need constant visual variety. Long stretches of talking head feel like a lecture.	Break it up every 3-5 seconds with relevant B-roll, images, or overlays.
Using clips under 3 seconds	Clips that flash for 1-2 seconds feel jarring. The viewer cannot process them.	Minimum 3 seconds per clip. If a clip is too short, find a longer one or extend with a still image.
Silently skipping lines with no B-roll	The editor discovers the gap during editing and the whole pipeline stalls.	Explicitly flag: [NO B-ROLL FOUND - need alternative]. The editor can then create a custom visual or overlay.
Reusing the same clip for multiple lines	Repetition looks lazy. The viewer notices.	Each script line needs a unique visual. If reusing clips, you need more sources.
Showing company logo instead of real footage	A logo is the weakest possible visual for a company. It adds almost no engagement.	Search for office footage, news coverage, product demos, or conference clips. Only use logos as brief overlays while host is speaking.
Stacking 3+ still images in a row	The video loses its dynamic rhythm and starts to feel like a slideshow.	Break up image sequences with at least one video clip every 2 images.

10. Final Deliverables Checklist

Before submitting your work, verify every item on this checklist. If any item is not complete, your submission is not ready.

10.1 Annotated Script Document

- Every line has at least one visual reference (B-roll, still image, or custom visual)
- All B-roll references use raw YouTube URLs with exact start-end timestamps
- All still image references use the [pic N] format with highlight instructions where needed
- Audio instructions are marked explicitly where B-roll should play with original audio
- Overlay instructions (logos, arrows, text) are noted inline
- Section transitions have visual bridges (clips, title cards, or custom graphics)
- Metaphor/analogy lines have creative visual treatments
- Any gaps are explicitly flagged with [NO B-ROLL FOUND - need alternative]

10.2 Image Folder

- All still images uploaded to Slack as a single folder
- Named sequentially: 1.png, 2.png, 3.png, etc.
- Every image is minimum 1280x720 resolution
- No watermarks, no low-res images, no uncropped browser screenshots
- Images match the numbered references in the annotated script

10.3 Custom Visuals (if applicable)

- Self-contained HTML files, one per visual
- Data is sourced and verified
- Designed for 16:9, legible at 1080p

10.4 Summary Counts

Include a brief summary at the top of your submission:

- Script duration: [X] minutes
- Total B-roll clips sourced: [X]
- Total still images created: [X]
- Total custom visuals created: [X]
- Number of unfilled gaps: [X] (target: 0)
- Percentage of stock footage: [X]% (target: under 10%)
- Number of era mismatches: [X] (target: 0)

11. Quick Reference Card

Print this page and keep it visible while working. All targets are based on real frame-by-frame data from our published documentaries.

Real Data Targets (From DaVinci Resolve Timeline Exports)

Metric	Target
Unique B-Roll sources	74-91 per video (~83 avg) | 5-7 per minute of script
Unique Still Images	57-68 per video (~63 avg) | 4-5 per minute of script
Custom Visuals (HTML files)	1-3 per video (NOT 7-10). Timelines, charts, data visualizations.
Still Image coverage (incl. zoom)	~22% of screen time; 91-93% include Ken Burns zoom/pan
Host on screen	~13% of screen time (avg streak: 2.5-4.5 seconds, stretches to 10-15 seconds during key moments)
B-Roll with original audio	~2% of total video (only high-impact moments)

Rules & Standards

Rule	Standard
Reference documentaries	JPM: youtu.be/bnLFyTIL5lQ | Solomon: youtube.com/watch?v=SfIjrEJt3SQ
Host face time between cuts	Target: 2-5 seconds. Normal range: up to 15 seconds during key narrative moments. Hard ceiling: ~15 seconds.
Minimum clip duration	3 seconds
Maximum single clip	10 seconds (then a cut is needed)
Stock footage ceiling	Under 10% of total B-roll
Unfilled gaps allowed	Zero (flag explicitly if needed)
Era mismatches allowed	Zero
Max consecutive still images	2 (then a video clip must break it up)
B-roll reference format	[raw URL, MM:SS - MM:SS]
Image reference format	[pic N] or [pic N, highlight "text"] or [pic N, zoom] or [pic N, pan left-to-right]
Audio callout format	[URL, timestamp, WITH AUDIO] (use sparingly)
Alternate options format	[option A] OR [option B]
Image naming	1.png, 2.png, 3.png...
Image minimum resolution	1280x720
Source priority	Interviews > Official > Documentary > News > Stock

Historical footage rule	Match the era of the event being discussed
Clip reuse	Never reuse the same clip for two different lines
Section transitions	Every section change needs a visual bridge
Metaphor treatment	Visualize the metaphor literally with creative clips
Still vs. B-Roll decision	Still for documents/info. B-Roll for people/action. Audio for high-impact quotes only.
15-minute script deliverable minimum	75-90 unique B-roll sources, 55-70 unique images (91-93% with zoom), 1-3 custom visual HTML files

FINAL REMINDER

If you are ever unsure whether you have enough material, you don't. Go find more. Overshooting by 20% is always preferable to a revision round that delays the entire production timeline. Watch both reference documentaries before starting and use them as your constant benchmark.